The Dining Room

By A. R. Gurney

JIM, comes in from the hall, followed by his daughter, MEG. He is in his late sixties, she is about thirty.

MEG: Where are you going now, Daddy?

JIM: I think your mother might want a drink.

MEG: She's reading to the children.

JIM: That's why she might want one.

MEG: She wants no such thing, Dad.

JIM: Then I want one.

MEG: Now? It's not even five.

JIM: Well then let's go see how the Red Sox are doing. *(He starts back out, R.)*

MEG: Daddy, stop!

JIM: Stop what?

MEG: Avoiding me. Ever since I arrived, we haven't been able to talk.

JIM: Good Lord, what do you mean? Seems to me everybody's been talking continuously and simultaneously from the moment you got off the plane.

MEG: Alone, Daddy. I mean alone. And you know I mean alone. . .

INTRODUCTION

Actor: Over 80 million adult children who have left home have returned to live with their parents. They call them "boomerang kids."
Actress: And the reasons are as varied as the grown children themselves. . . financial hardships, failed marriages,
Actor: In this scene, Meg broaches the very serious prospect of returning to her parents home with her three small children. The discussion takes place in
Actress: The Dining Room by AR Gurney.

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JIM: All right. We'll talk. *(Sits down.)* Right here in the dining room. Good place to talk. Why not? Matter of fact, I'm kind of tired. It's been a long day. .

MEG: I love this room. I've always loved it. Always.

JIM: Your mother and I still use it. Now and then. Once a week. Mrs. Robinson still comes in and cooks us a nice dinner and we have it in here. Still. Lamb chops. Broilers

MEG: *(Suddenly.)* I've left him, Daddy.

JIM: Oh well now, a little vacation. . .

MEG: I've left him permanently.

JIM: Yes, well, permanently is a very long word. . .

MEG: I can't live with him, Dad. We don't get along at all.

JIM: Oh well, you may think that now. . . .

MEG: Could we live here, Dad?

JIM: Here?

MEG: For a few months.

JIM: With three small children?

MEG: While I work out my life. *(Pause. JIM takes out a pocket watch and looks at it.)*

JIM: What time is it? A little after five. I think the sun is over the yardarm, don't you? Or if it isn't, it should be. I think it's almost permissible for you and me to have a little drink, Meg.

MEG: Can we stay here, Dad?

JIM: Make us a drink, Meggie.

MEG: All right. *(She goes into the kitchen; the door, of course, remains open.)*

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JIM: *(Calling to her.)* I'd like Scotch, sweetheart. Make it reasonably strong. You'll find the silver measuring gizmo in the drawer by the trays. I want two shots and a splash of water. And I like to use that big glass with the pheasant on it. And not too much ice. *(He gets up and moves around the table.)*

MEG'S VOICE: *(Within.)* All right.

JIM: I saw Mimi Mott the other day. . . Can you hear me?

MEG's VOICE: *(Within.)* I can hear you, Dad.

JIM: There she was, being a very good sport with her third husband. Her third. Who's deaf as a post and extremely disagreeable. So I took her aside-can you hear me?

MEG's VOICE: *(Within.)* I'm listening, Dad.

JIM: I took her aside, and I said, "Now Mimi; tell me the truth. If you had made half as much effort with your first husband as you've made with the last two, don't you think you'd still be wed to him?" I asked her that. Point blank. And you know what Mimi said? She said, "Maybe." That's I exactly what she said. "Maybe." If she had made the effort. *(MEG returns with two glasses. She gives one to JIM.)*

MEG: That's your generation, Dad.

JIM: That's every generation.

MEG: It's not mine.

JIM: Every generation has to make an effort.

MEG: I won't go back to him, Dad. I want to be here.

JIM: *(Looking at his glass.)* I wanted the glass with the pheasant on it.

MEG: I think the kids used it.

JIM: Oh. *(Pause. He drinks; moves away from her.)*

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MEG: SO can we stay, Dad? ,

JIM: I sleep in your room now. Your mother kicked me out because I snore. And we use the boys' room now to watch TV.

MEG: I'll use the guest room.

JIM: And the children?

MEG: They can sleep on the third floor. In the maid's rooms.

JIM: We closed them off. Because of the oil bills.

MEG: I don't care, Dad. We'll work it out. Please. *(Pause. He sits down at the other end of the table.)*

JIM: Give it another try first.

MEG: No.

JIM: Another try.

MEG: He's got someone else now, Dad. She's living there right now. She's moved in.

JIM: Then fly back and kick her out.

MEG: Oh, Dad. . .

JIM: I'm serious. You don't know this, but that's what your mother did. One time I became romantically involved with Mrs. Shoemaker. We took a little trip together. To Ashland. Your mother got wind of it, and came right down. . . told Betty Shoemaker to get on the next train. That's all there was to it. Now why don't you do that? Go tell that woman to peddle her papers elsewhere. We'll sit with the children while you do.

MEG: I've got someone too, Dad. *(Pause.)*

JIM: You mean you've had a little fling.

MEG: I've been going with someone.

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JIM: A little fling.

MEG: I've been living with him.

JIM: Where was your husband?

MEG: He stayed with his girl.

JIM: And your children?

MEG: Oh they. . . came and went.

JIM: It sounds a little. . . complicated.

MEG: It is, Dad. That's why I needed to come home. *(Pause. He drinks.)*

JIM: Now let's review the bidding, may we? Do you plan to marry this new man?

MEG: No.

JIM: You're not in love with him?

MEG: No. He's already married, anyway.

JIM: And he's decided he loves his wife.

MEG: No.

JIM: But you've decided you don't love him.

MEG: Yes.

JIM: Or your husband.

MEG: Yes.

JIM: And your husband's fallen in love with someone else.

MEG: He lives with someone else.

JIM: And your children. . . my grandchildren... come and go among these various households.

MEG: Yes. Sort of. Yes.

JIM: Sounds extremely complicated. . .

MEG: It is, Dad. It really is. *(Pause. He drinks. thinks, gets up, paces.)*

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JIM: Well then it seems to me the first thing you do is simplify things. That's the first thing. You ask the man you're living with to leave, you sue your husband for divorce, you hold onto your house, you keep the children in their present schools, you . . .

MEG: There's someone else, Dad. *(Pause.)*

JIM: Someone else?

MEG: Someone else entirely.

JIM: A third person.

MEG: Yes.

JIM: What was that movie your mother and I liked so much? The Third Man? *(He sits)*

MEG: It's not a man, Dad. *(Pause.)*

JIM: Not a man.

MEG: It's a woman.

JIM: A woman.

MEG: I've been involved with a woman, Dad, but it's not working, and I don't know who I am, and I've got to touch base, Daddy. I want to be here. *(She kneels at his feet. Pause. JIM gets slowly to his feet. He points to his glass.)*

JIM: I think I'll get a repair. Would you like a repair? I'll take your glass. I'll get us both repairs. *(He takes her glass and goes out to the kitchen, leaving the door open.)*

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MEG: *(Moving around the dining room.)* I'm all mixed up, Dad. I'm all over the ball park. I've been seeing a Crisis Counselor, and I've taken a part-time job, and I've been jogging two miles a day, and none of it's working, Dad. I want to come home. I want to take my children to the Zoo, and the Park Lake, and the Art Gallery, and do all those things you and Mother used to do with all of us. I want to start again, Dad. I want to start all over again. *(JIM comes out from the kitchen, now carrying three glasses.)*

JIM: I made one for your mother. And I found the glass with the pheasant on it. In the trash. Somebody broke it. *(He crosses for the doorway, R.)* So let's have a nice cocktail with your mother, and see if we can get the children to sit quietly while we do.

MEG: You don't want us here, do you, Dad?

JIM: *(Stopping.)* Of course we do, darling. A week, ten days. You're most welcome.

MEG: *(Desperately.)* I can't go back, Dad!

JIM: *(Quietly.)* Neither can I, sweetheart. Neither can I. *(He shuffles on out. MEG stands for a moment in the dining room, then hurries out after him.)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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